



Life out west was dangerous for settlers for a variety of reasons. Although newspapers emphasized the potential danger of Native American warfare, most settler fatalities came from sickness and deprivation.

The Donner Party, a group of 87 western migrants trapped in California's Sierra Nevada mountains in the winter of 1846, famously cannibalized members of their own party in order to survive in the face of starvation and hypothermia. Forty people died, and the incident became a symbol of the dangers of western settlement. Within the party, more men died than women—this

is sometimes attributed to the fact that women stayed inside the wagons to look after children, whereas young, single men were more active and so the most at risk. Women also have lower daily caloric needs and maintain a higher ratio of body fat, which is thought to have aided their survival.

Pioneers

The Homestead Act was especially popular with single, widowed, or divorced women, and later, immigrants. Although these women made singular claims, they were not alone in the west but became part of the new communities that built up.

Lucy Goldthorpe, for example, was a young, single woman who claimed a homestead in Williams County, North Dakota, in 1905. There, she continued her previous career as

◀ Sharp shooter

Annie Oakley was one of a few women who made a living as an entertainer, dazzling viewers at Buffalo Bill Cody's Wild West show with her marksmanship.



a teacher, and even hosted Christmas dinner for other single women and young men from nearby homesteads. Success stories like Goldthorpe's were not limited to white women. Former slaves were granted the right to make homesteading claims in 1866, and many took up the offer of a new life. An African American woman named Agnes Morgan moved west around 1880 as a domestic servant to a white family, but in time was able to claim her own property in Granite County, Montana, and create an independent life for herself.

Gambling was a problem in the so-called "Wild West" and some pioneer women contributed to it. Eleanor Dumont, a gambler, opened a number of saloons in Nevada City, California, before losing everything and taking her own life in 1879. Alice Ivers opened her own saloon in Dakota territory in the 1870s, but was arrested after killing a violent patron.